



IN CONTEXT

GENRE
Comedy

DIRECTOR
Billy Wilder

WRITERS
**I. A. L. Diamond,
Billy Wilder**

STARS
**Marilyn Monroe, Jack
Lemmon, Tony Curtis**

BEFORE
1953 *Gentlemen Prefer Blondes*, Howard Hawks's musical comedy, is an early hit for Marilyn Monroe.

1955 In Billy Wilder's romantic comedy, *The Seven Year Itch*, Monroe poses on a subway grate, an updraft lifts her dress.

AFTER
1960 *The Apartment* reunites Jack Lemmon with Billy Wilder for a darker, more cynical take on romantic comedy.

1961 John Huston's *The Misfits* is Monroe's last movie.

WELL, NOBODY'S PERFECT

SOME LIKE IT HOT / 1959

The final words of *Some Like It Hot*, "Nobody's perfect," could have been writer/director Billy Wilder's motto. His movies are case studies of the fatally flawed and the cheerfully cynical, the suckers, hustlers, and fraudsters who are motivated by money and sex and not much else.

Set at the tail end of the Roaring Twenties, *Some Like It Hot* is no exception. Its main characters are as selfish, deceitful, and grasping



This poster flaunts the glamour of its starry cast, but other versions of this group shot show the two leading men dressed in drag.

as they come—they'll do anything to get what they want. But Wilder's movie is also a breezy feel-good comedy that sparkles with charm, pathos, and the spirit of romance.

Money and lust

Tony Curtis and Jack Lemmon play Joe and Jerry, two Chicago jazz musicians who disguise themselves as women to flee the mob after they witness a gangster shootout during the famous Saint Valentine's Day Massacre of 1929. They join an all-girl orchestra en route to Florida and meet vocalist Sugar Kane (Marilyn Monroe), who dreams of bagging a millionaire husband. Joe falls head over heels in lust and disguises himself again, this time as a playboy, in a bid to bed the singer. He's after sex, she's after money, but they also fall in love.

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Hilariously innocent, though always on the brink of really disastrous double-entendre.

Pauline Kael

5001 Nights at the Movies, 1982

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